
The Etiquette Tip That Helps Me Keep My Cool—and Get What I Want—in Tense Email Exchanges

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This is [One Thing](#), a column with tips on how to live.

It started when I was writing an angry email to my insurance company. It seemed like they were going to deny coverage for some medical tests that I was sure they were supposed to pay for. When I complained to my therapist about it, I explained that I was going to send them a response along the lines of: *Listen you corrupt clowns, I already sent you the forms you requested five times so this is obviously just a typical ruse to get out of paying.*

He reminded me that I can be, well, a little bit of an impatient hothead. His advice was to draft a response, and then wait eight hours before sending it. Waiting would allow me to process the actual information in the insurance company's message, and to calm down. Most importantly, being in a less reactive state would give me a better shot at attaining my actual goal—getting medical coverage—instead of simply insulting a customer service person. Since my longtime therapist's behavioral approach had already helped rein in my personality enough to quit smoking and drinking, and marry a great guy, I decided to try his suggestion. The email I ended up sending began: "Thank you so much for your help with this complicated matter." Insurance ended up reimbursing me completely.

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Aha! I realized that replying to complicated requests or problems in anger or haste was never smart, so I kept his rule to slow my response time down eight hours for future correspondence.

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It's useful in situations that elicit any kind of strong emotions, not just anger. More recently, an ex-boyfriend I hadn't seen in years emailed me a request to loan him \$4,000. He'd been sick, so I feared he might need the money for something serious. Could he not afford medical care? We'd dated after college; I'd always felt guilty I'd ended the relationship. I wondered if I could afford to lose the \$4,000. What if he died before repaying?

Recalling my therapist's mandate, I didn't answer right away. Just because someone contacted me didn't obligate me to reply instantly. Hours later my ex shared more info unprompted, revealing he needed money because a Russian woman he was involved with couldn't afford the tuition for her son (who lived in Moscow!). What a scam. I told him so, refusing to comply and letting him know that he shouldn't be giving away money he needed to borrow.

I was glad I kept my rule. Now I try to slow down all complicated or heated electronic correspondence for at least a day, sometimes a weekend. If you're like me, eight hours can feel like a long time, but it isn't, and waiting can be like giving a great present to yourself.

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